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1 mysterious company, 603 abandoned oil wells

Tribune investigation shows Fireball was able to evade responsibility, exposing communities to contaminants and saddling Illinois with millions in cleanup costs

By Jonathan Bullington and Adriana Pérez | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

CUMBERLAND COUNTY — There seems to be few people around these days who know much, if anything, about Fireball Production Inc. Not the oil industry leaders. Not the state regulators. Not the residents of this downstate county littered with hundreds of holes in the ground.

They apparently hadn't heard, or couldn't remember, that 36 years ago, with global oil prices in a free fall, the oddly named company made an odd business decision: It purchased hundreds of aging wells in a depleted oil field.

The company claimed the wells would be sold for parts and then plugged. But staff at the Illinois Department of Mines and Minerals — then the agency tasked with overseeing oil production — suspected something was amiss with the sale. They asked the state attorney general's office for help collecting unpaid fees that, by the spring of 1991, had reached \$45,500.

"Certainly," a department attorney wrote to the AG's office, "there is a sense that this may have been a fraudulent conveyance."

Neither agency, though, could save Illinois from the far steeper financial burden that lay ahead, or the environmental hazards those abandoned wells would pose.

Above: An abandoned well rests in farmland near Casey, Ill., on Feb. 11. According to Illinois Department of Natural Resources records, it appears to be an abandoned Fireball well. The mysterious company abandoned 603 wells in Illinois. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A four-month Chicago Tribune investigation, drawing on hundreds of pages of previously unreleased public records and interviews with former state officials and oil operators, has revealed the startling ease with which Fireball was able to evade its legal responsibility for plugging wells that have stopped producing, exposing downstate communities to a host of contaminants — above and below ground — while saddling the state with millions in cleanup costs.

In Fireball's case, state data show, the company ultimately abandoned 603 wells.

Its sudden and short-lived foray into Illinois' oil business is estimated to cost the state around \$24 million.

See **FIREBALL** on Page A12

'Our friend in Burr Ridge'

Restaurant owner in Indiana gambling case once featured in Outfit beating plot

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The plot to hire some mob-connected tough guys to break the legs of a debtor allegedly began in May 2013 with vague talk over a wire-tapped phone call about a popular restaurateur in Chicago's western suburbs, federal court records show.

"Well uh, our other friend over there in Burr Ridge wants to talk to us about a job," reputed soldier Paul Carparelli told his accomplice, George Brown, a beefy labor union bodyguard, according to the records. "I'll go meet him and see what it is and I'll brief ya on it ... He says it's a money maker."

The "friend" in Burr Ridge was Filippo "Gigi" Rovito, the owner of Capri Ristorante, an old-school staple known for its "Wise Guy" meatballs and frequented by politicians and mobsters alike, the court records show. And the job? Help Rovito's friend, Outfit associate Michael "Mickey" Davis, send a discreet but violent message to a Melrose Park car dealer who owed him \$300,000.

Carporelli assembled a crew to get the beating done, and picked up a \$5,000 down payment from Davis at Capri. But the assault never took place. It turned out that Brown was cooperating with the FBI, leading to a slew of indictments that sent Carparelli, Davis and several others to federal prison — but not Rovito, who was never charged.

Now, more than a decade later, Rovito has been named in another federal case with plenty of mob flavor: "Operation Porterhouse Parlay," a sprawling investigation into an illicit sports gambling ring allegedly based out of two Greek-

See **GAMBLING** on Page A4

Little light shed on who runs nonprofits

Almost none comply with law meant to expose diversity gaps

By Dan Petrella
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As June 2024 came to a close, Gov. JB Pritzker was characteristically bullish while he marked the end of Pride Month by signing into law a requirement that Illinois' largest nonprofit foundations disclose the demographic makeup of their boards of directors and officers.

"Here in Illinois, we reject hate,

bigotry, and discrimination and embrace the ethos of Pride through not only our laws but through our actions and shared values," Pritzker said in a statement released after a bill signing event at the Fat Cat bar and restaurant in Uptown. He soon added that the disclosure requirement represented an expansion of his "administration's work to better serve the LGBTQ+ community of Illinois."

But nearly two years later, the measure has shed little light on who actually runs these organizations — and may never do so.

As of mid-April, only three of

the largest grantmaking foundations in Illinois had published the required demographic information on their websites as the law outlines — disclosing the makeup of their leadership across categories including LGBTQ+ identity, gender, race and ethnicity, disability status and military service: the MacArthur Foundation, the Polk Bros. Foundation and the Lloyd A. Fry Foundation, according to a Tribune review. A fourth, the Chicago Community Trust, had some demographic information available on its website and

See **NONPROFITS** on Page A6



State Sen. Adriane Johnson, right, speaks to state Sen. Omar Aquino on the Senate floor before the session begins at the Illinois Capitol building in Springfield on May 7. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE

CHICAGO SPORTS

Remembering Sianis and love of baseball

As the City Series between the Cubs and White Sox plays out on the South Side, Sam Sianis and the Curse of the Billy Goat remind Chicago fans why we love baseball and its myths, writes Paul Sullivan.

OPINION CHICAGO 2050

Building the city for a bright future

At its core, Chicago 2050 is about delivering on a simple truth: that every resident in every neighborhood is able to live, work and thrive in a safe and affordable city, Mayor Brandon Johnson writes. **Page B2**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY
H: 86
L: 71
MON.
H: 83
L: 71
TUE.
H: 79
L: 49
Complete details on Page A22

INDEX

Almanac A17
Crossword . . . In Comics
Editorials B1

Horoscope . . . In Comics
Letters B3
Obituaries A18

Rides G7
Success G4
Television E7

178th year No. 137
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